
**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic A6: The
Wars of the Roses
in England, 1455-
85**

The focus of this topic is the bloody, if intermittent, struggle between noble factions grouped around the royal houses of York and Lancaster from the first battle at St Albans in May 1455 to the Tudor triumph at Bosworth Field in August 1485. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of royal power and the challenges to that power in the reigns of Henry VI, Edward IV and Richard III. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, foreign aid played an important part in the successful challenges of Warwick in 1470, Edward in 1471 and Henry Tudor in 1485 (bullet points 3 and 4).

The first bullet point relates to why fighting broke out in 1455. Students should understand the complex interaction of causation involving: the personal deficiencies of Henry VI and the personality of Margaret of Anjou; the financial weakness of the crown; the impact of defeat in France; the position and claims of Richard Duke of York; and the local rivalries of the great magnates such as Percy and Neville in the north and Bonville and Courteney in the south-west.